

NEWSLETTER



Dear friends and family,

I hope everyone has been doing well! My second year of Via is in full swing and we have had a very eventful fall. With this newsletter, I want to give some insight into what I have been doing for the past few months in Via Nova and how it has impacted my life.

Via is a unique opportunity to spend nine months intentionally building a spiritual, professional, and intellectual foundation that is geared toward preparing young adults for their next step in life. For me, Via has been incredibly influential in my discernment of a future career path and has provided me with a rich experience of friendship and mentorship. Our daily life as Fellows is structured in a way that helps build good habits and practices.

This past July, I had an amazing opportunity to spend a month studying at the Sacred Art School in Florence, Italy. Several contemporary artists that I really admire have studied or taught there, including my art mentor from last year, Blair Piras. I took an intensive four week

course where I was instructed in the classical techniques of drawing and oil painting, with an emphasis on working from life and with live models. I absolutely loved it! My instructors and the other students were so kind and it was a month filled with so much grace and joy!

Florence itself is a city that lives and breathes art and is the home of some of the greatest artists who have ever lived, so it was really inspiring to be able to walk in their footsteps. Everywhere I went I was surrounded by art and I saw some of the most beautiful buildings, churches, paintings, and sculptures I've ever seen.



scenes from Florence

My hope is to return in the near future to continue my studies in the tradition of sacred art so that I can bring what I learn back to South Louisiana!

My experience in Florence was really clarifying in discerning the next steps that I should take in life, but it also increased my desire to pursue my intellectual and spiritual formation. So based on my time in Via last year and the fruits that I am still receiving from it, I decided to commit to another year. Already the past few months have been so abundant and joy filled! I've broken the rest of my newsletter down into sections on the three pillars of Via Nova plus some extra aspects that I would like to highlight.

STUDY

This year, I've been trying to lean into Via's intellectual formation as much as I can and so far, our discussions have been really fruitful. We have a full-time tutor, John Lindsley, who has been guiding us through our reading material in seminars and small group mentorship. Having a singular primary tutor is one way that this year differs from last and it's been really helpful to be able to follow a continuous thread of conversation and ideas with John throughout all of the works we study. We started the year studying Plato's *Republic* back in August and continued throughout September. I always love reading the pre-Christian philosophers because I am struck by how much truth they are able to reach

just through their reason alone. They provide a really solid and rational framework for how to live your life that is surprisingly similar to the call to virtue in the Gospel message.

For my presentation on the Greek philosophy sequence, I explored Plato's idea of the arts, specifically how he sees them as a threat or danger to morality. The idea that art can be a dangerous distraction from the Good or a tool for deception is important for us to recognize as Catholics. Even Saint Augustine writes about his struggle with getting distracted by beautiful art. But there is also great power found in art that can be a catalyst for deeper conversion. If rightly ordered, art can be a tool that guides us toward the Good, which is God, the Divine Artist.



seminar with John Lindsley

At the beginning of September, we went on our Fall Retreat in Covington, Louisiana. Dr. Ian Gerdon, a professor of theology at the University of Notre Dame,

led our discussions on the early Church Fathers, dopamine culture, and essays on knowledge by John Henry Newman. We learned about Evagrius of Pontus, a Desert Father, and his teachings on the eight tempting thoughts, which are the foundation for Gregory's seven deadly sins. We were able to go in depth into what might trigger the tempting thoughts and how we can recognize them and guard against them. I also really enjoyed talking about John Henry Newman's Sermon 14 on Christian wisdom. He explores the relationship between wisdom and knowledge in a way that was really helpful for me. Newman argues that it's not worth much to have a lot of facts about something if it isn't affecting how one sees and judges the world. I really liked how he explained living knowledge as the continual connection of knowledge and ideas that should lead to the enlargement of mind and help form one's "moral center" and lead one closer to Christ.



Now, we are working our way through Sacred Scripture. We spent several weeks discussing Genesis, contrasting it with the creation stories from different ancient

civilizations. We also spent a lot of time talking about divine authorship and the idea of the literal interpretation presented by Augustine, which I really enjoyed learning about! Studying Exodus, we followed the same ideas that we began in Genesis such as the Abrahamic Covenant and the importance of the patriarchy, the ordering of family life and marriage, the evolution of cities and culture, and the abundance of forgiveness that is poured out on God's chosen people.

Then we moved to Job, the Psalms, and Ecclesiastes and focused mainly on the themes of faithfulness, righteousness, suffering, and hope. The Church Fathers hold that the Psalms contain and recapitulate the whole of Sacred Scriptures and salvation history, which is honestly mind-blowing sometimes. They speak about Christ's life and death and are even quoted by Him throughout His ministry and during His Passion. Not only are the Psalms really fruitful to study, but they are also really fruitful to pray with. They serve the tradition of the Church as its universal prayer through the Liturgy of the Hours, which is part of our communal prayer in Via.

WORK

My work this year looks a little different from last year as I'm doing less apprenticing and more personal work. My Tuesdays are devoted to painting practice and working on commissions. I finished

my first commissioned sacred art oil painting and I am very pleased with how it turned out! The whole project was a really good learning experience for me as I am still a beginner in oil painting and it has also been a good opportunity to reflect on the lives of St. Mary and St. Anne as I paint them. I hope this is just the first of many sacred art pieces that I get to create!



“Saint Anne Teaching Saint Mary”
2024

On Thursdays, I teach an art class to my younger sisters and their homeschooled friends. This has been a lot of fun for me. I also occasionally have a booth at the Lafayette Farmers and Artisans Market in Moncus Park on Saturday mornings. I really enjoy the market because it is a chance to showcase some of my smaller paintings and art prints. I have found that this is a good way to get a larger audience and meet some really cool people!

PRAYER

Time in prayer in front of the Blessed Sacrament and Holy Mass are a part of our schedule every day. I see this as a great privilege because not many people have anything like this built into their schedule. The intentionality that it takes to show up at the chapel at the same time every day is not something that I would normally commit to, but it has been really helpful in making sure that I prioritize prayer. I am in no way a morning person, so having prayer as the first thing that we do has been both a grace and a struggle, but there is something really good about showing up for the Lord even when I am tired. And it's just a really great way to start my day. If you have any particular intentions you would like me to pray for, please don't hesitate to reach out!

In October, I was able to go on the Three Hearts Pilgrimage in Oklahoma with three of the other Fellows and some teachers and students from JPG. We walked close to 35 miles to Clear Creek Monastery in Hulbert, Oklahoma over two days, ending with a Solemn High Mass. I've never really done anything like this, and there were some parts that were very hard, but it was in that struggle that I think the Lord was moving in my heart. As a person living in 21st century America, the idea of walking 20 miles in one day was wild to me, and by the end of the first day, my whole body hurt. But in the campsite where around 3000 pilgrims were spending the night

in tents, there was an air of joy and camaraderie that was really beautiful. It was really inspiring for me to see so many people sacrificing their time and energy for the greater glory of God! This experience helped me realize the importance of perseverance in prayer and how important it is to focus on loving the Lord even when prayer feels hard or pointless. We weren't just walking for no reason, we had a destination in mind and that helped me put everything, even the suffering, into perspective.



Three Hearts Pilgrimage 2024

COMMUNITY LIFE

One of the biggest joys of the past few months has definitely been my community. I'm so privileged to be able to live with a small group of young people who have the same desire to grow in holiness and knowledge of the faith that I do. Having a strong community makes even the mundane day-to-day tasks, like cleaning the kitchen after an event or working on our presentations, a lot easier whenever you get to do them in community.



Dr. Gerdon's talk: Lost in the Cosmos

Another one of my favorite aspects of the last few months are the weekly events we host for the wider community to join in and get a little bit of the Via experience. These can be anywhere from more formal talks to more chill events and parties. Before our Fall Retreat Dr. Ian Gerdon gave a talk at the women's house and over 60 people came to hear him speak about the cosmos and the longing for home that humans experience.

We've also had two Dinner and Discussion nights where we looked at Scripture and the Church Fathers and other Church Traditions to try to bring clarity to specific topics. Our first discussion was on the apparent disconnect between the wrathful God in the Old Testament and the loving message that Christ brings. Our most recent discussion was on sports and Christian virtue. I've found it helpful to hear these things being talked about and done in a way that allows for a lot of different angles and opinions to be

assessed. And we've hosted more casual events like poetry nights and Cajun jam nights which have been really fun.



Poetry night on the porch

Since the whole of my formation is fundraised, I think these events are really good opportunities to give back to those who have shown me so much generosity. They are also a chance for me to have conversations with people that I perhaps wouldn't have otherwise and to invite those people that are close to me into part of what I'm spending this year doing.

PILGRIMAGE

In October, we went on our Fall Pilgrimage to the West, which included stops in Colorado and Wyoming and ended with a visit to Our Lady of Clear Creek Abbey in Oklahoma. It was such a good trip and reflecting on it, there are three aspects that I think are worth giving attention to.

First is that none of it would have been possible without the generosity of so



The Fellows and Luke in
Buena Vista, CO

many people. I saw so much kindness all throughout this trip from our hosts, friends, and from everyone praying for us back at home. Even the 12-passenger van that we spent almost 60 hours driving in was being lent to us.

It was also a really wonderful opportunity to spend intentional time with the other Fellows and be present to them in a way which is typically harder back home in Lafayette. We were encouraged to take a break from our phones and any tech and that made being present to each other a lot easier. It definitely made a difference on the kinds of activities and conversations that happened. Our host in Wyoming, a friend of Luke's, is an absolute treasure and her presence to us was such a gift! She helped organize a lot of group activities that were definitely some of the highlights of the pilgrimage. My favorite was the horseback trail ride that we went on.



Horseback riding in Wyoming

And finally, the whole trip was full of natural beauty. Whether it was through taking the scenic drive through the vibrant aspens in mountains, going on a hike to the Sacred Rim where the view at the top was breathtaking, or just sitting on the porch in Wyoming and watching the cows in the fields, there were so many moments that felt like something out of a painting!



Elise and me plein air painting on the porch in Wyoming



The Fellows at the peak of Sacred Rim



Ellen, Elise, and me

Thank you to everyone who has supported me and is praying for me! It truly means so much to have people investing in my formation. Again, please know of my prayers and please feel free to reach out with any special intentions.

In Christ,

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